TreeHouse at St. Paul's

"Establishing Strong Roots for
Christian Development."

Early Childhood Center

Parent and Family Handbook

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Welcome to TreeHouse

Welcome to TreeHouse at St. Paul's. We are thrilled that you have enrolled your child(ren) in our program and look forward to welcoming you to our family! We know there are many wonderful Early Childhood Centers in the South County area and are pleased that you have chosen TreeHouse!

TreeHouse has offered quality early childhood education since 1976. Our experienced and educated staff provides a quality Christian experience for infants 6 weeks of age through 5 years old. Our program offers year round care to families.

This handbook has been designed to provide you with important information about the policies and procedures of our Christian-based program. We ask that you read this handbook thoroughly and keep it for reference throughout the year.

Just a small note about TreeHouse: We are an educational childcare facility. Our tuition rates for those enrolled in our programs are determined by overall cost, not an hourly figure. Our tuition remains the same regardless of absences or holiday/work day/inclement weather closings.

If you have any questions or concerns, please ask your child's teacher. Also, please feel free to call the TreeHouse Office at (314) 894-0079.

Welcome to the TreeHouse at St. Paul's!

Nancy Schmitz

Director, TreeHouse at St. Paul's

nancys@sp4u.org

Our Mission

The mission of TreeHouse is to provide quality, Christian education and childcare to Oakville residents and surrounding communities. Additionally, it is our goal to nurture children's knowledge and understanding of God, Jesus, the Bible, the Church, prayer, and themselves and others as children of God. TreeHouse is a vital part of the ministry of St. Paul's Church as we remain dedicated to caring for the changing needs of families through preschool with extended care.

The TreeHouse program continues in its mission of offering families a Christian learning and loving-rich environment, providing children with opportunities to "establish strong roots for future development."

Our Philosophy

"Let the children come to me…." Matthew 19:14a

TreeHouse is designed to allow children to actively develop knowledge as they interact with their physical and social world, under the guidelines of Project Construct. Project Construct is a process-oriented curriculum based on the premise that children grow and obtain knowledge through their interaction with four major domains: socio-moral, cognitive, representational, and physical. The major goal of this program is to foster the development of a child's moral and intellectual autonomy. Moral autonomy is the ability to make decisions for one-self and to regulate one's own behaviors, without constant monitoring by others. Children will become self-directed. Intellectual autonomy is the freedom to think; to come to knowledge through many avenues. Children are encouraged to experience, discover, observe and form their own conclusions.

Teachers guide and facilitate this growth by providing needed motivation, praise, and re-direction. The environment is structured so that children are successful. The teachers are sensitive to the world of the young child and through this world new doors of imagination, learning and friendships are opened.

Four principles that are integral to Project Construct and guide the curriculum and assessment are:

- Children have an intrinsic desire to make sense of their world.
- Children actively construct knowledge and values by interacting with the physical and social worlds.
- In their universal effort to understand the world, children's thinking will contain predictable errors.

- Children's development is an interactive and interrelated process and spans the Socio-moral, Cognitive, Representational and Physical Development domains.

> *"…And sometimes when the classroom is so noisy and buzzing with activity, I just have to stop and remember that in here there is no boredom, no aimlessness, and no blind obedience. I know my children are thinking, and that's the best preparation I can give them for today as well as tomorrow."*

Hours of Operation

Full Day, year-round programs for children ages 6 weeks through 5 years of age

Monday-Friday 6:30 am – 6:00 pm

Programs

Infant Toddler (6 weeks through 2 years of age)

2-3 Year Old Preschool (child must be 2 years of age at enrollment)

Mixed Ages Preschool Program (child must be 3 years of age and fully potty trained)

- Monday, Wednesday, Friday (3 day schedule)
- Tuesday, Thursday (2 day schedule)
- Monday – Friday (5 day schedule)

Snow/Inclement Weather Days

We will follow the Mehlville School District regarding snow day closures. If MSD is closed due to inclement weather, TreeHouse will also be closed. There will be potential for an early release. We will announce the exact times via Brightwheel. Our goal is to provide a safe place for our students while not putting families at risk. We will alert all families via Brightwheel.

Severe Weather / Tornado Warning Release Policy

The safety of children and staff is our highest priority. When a **Tornado Warning** has been issued for our area, the preschool will immediately implement severe weather safety procedures and move all children and staff to designated shelter areas within the building.

During an active Tornado Warning, **children will not be released for pick-up**. For safety reasons, families will not be permitted to enter or exit the building until the warning has expired and an “all clear” has been issued by local authorities.

This policy is in place to prevent children and families from being exposed to dangerous weather conditions and to ensure all individuals remain in a secure shelter location.

Once the warning has ended and it is safe to do so, normal dismissal and pick-up procedures will resume.

We appreciate your understanding and cooperation as we prioritize the safety and well-being of all children in our care.

Fee Information

A registration fee of $100 per child or $150 for a family is due **at the time of enrollment**. The registration fee is not refundable.

- Tuition for those who attend infant/toddler care, or preschool is paid in bi-weekly installments thru ACH withdrawals. Fees are not refundable and do not carry over. Fees are paid for expected attendance. **Please note- There are no refunds or credits for illness, or days that the center is closed, including holidays, teacher workdays and inclement weather days.**
- Upon enrollment, you will receive a calendar stating the dates on which tuition will be withdrawn.
- Families who choose to withdraw for the summer and reserve their child's placement for the fall will be charged 25% of their regular tuition during the hold period.

TreeHouse offers a 10% discount for the oldest child's tuition if a family enrolls more than one child.

Any additional fees needed for activities such as assemblies will be deducted from your account on file via ACH. You will be notified of the cost and will consent prior to the fee being withdrawn.

The center closes promptly at 6:00 PM. A late fee of $1.00 per minute, per child, will be charged for any pick-up occurring after 6:00 PM. This fee will be automatically added to your account.

Please direct any questions you have regarding payment of tuition and fees to the director by phone at 314-894-0079 or by email at nancys@sp4u.org. The classroom teachers cannot answer questions regarding tuition or fees.

Programs

Early childhood is a vital development time for your children. TreeHouse at St. Paul's Learning Center is pleased to offer a quality, constructivist-based, Christian education for your child.

Infant-Toddler, Preschool

6:30am-6:00pm
Two (Tu/Th), Three (MWF), or Five (M-F) Days per Week
Infants and Toddlers class: 6 weeks through 2years
2-3 year old class (must be 2 at time of enrollment)
3, 4, and 5 year olds

Tree House at St. Paul's offers a full day experience for infants and toddlers, two year olds, and preschoolers. This full day experience includes added opportunities for the child to interact, explore and enjoy the rich learning environment.

Teachers prepare and share with parents weekly or bi-weekly lesson plans guided by the Project Construct Curriculum. In addition, each classroom will post activities, pictures, and videos throughout the day so parents of children can see the little students in action meeting the goals teachers have planned for them.

Children attend Chapel Time once a week with the Pastors of St. Paul's UCC-Pastor Erica and Pastor Mike. Chapel Time is child friendly and interactive and a big part of our Constructivist program.

All programs begin at 6:30 am. Children begin with breakfast and a choice of activities. (Breakfast is served until 8am) Children participate in Project Construct activities throughout the day. Children will also be served a morning and afternoon snack. Snacks are provided by parents once a month. The children enjoy lunch (brought from home) and an afternoon rest together. There are more gross motor and preschool activities available for the remainder of their day. The program ends at 6:00 pm. Our program operates year round.

Attendance, Drop Off and Pick Up Procedures

Punctuality and regularity are an important part of your child's character training. Our full day program is open from 6:30am until 6:00pm.

All enrolled 2 year old and PreK families will be issued a key fob which will allow entry to our main building Monday through Friday between the hours of 6:30am and 6:00pm. Key fobs will not work prior to 6:30am or after 6:00 pm, on holidays, or on weekends.

Families with infants and toddlers enrolled in the Baby House will need to ring the doorbell to gain entry into that building.

Only authorized persons shall pick-up a child from any classroom. Parents or caregivers MUST list all people who will pick up their child(ren) in the Brightwheel app as “Family” or “Approved Pickup”. Each child will be signed in and signed out daily in Brightwheel by their teacher. Upon enrollment, you will be added to this system.

Parking for drop off and pick up is located in the rear parking lot and in front of the Infant and Toddler Building. Children in the 2 year old and PreK classrooms will be met at the main door and escorted to their classrooms when dropped off. Please do not leave your car in the fire lane at drop off or pick up.

All children must be picked up by 6pm.

Classroom Information

Ratios

Tree House class size is based on the following ratios:

1 teacher for every 4 children (infant/toddler)

1 teacher for every 8 children (2 year olds)

1 teacher for every 10 children (ages 3-5)

Tree House teachers work as a team with each teacher being responsible for management of that class.

Housekeeping

CLOTHING Children should be dressed in play clothes and tennis shoes. (Please do not allow your child to wear flip flops to school.) A wide variety of activities will take place at the center so clothes that allow for freedom of movement and some soil are recommended. **We do get dirty from time to time!** While every attempt is made to protect your child’s clothing, please remember that some of our art and sensory experiences may stain clothing!

Please be sure that your child is dressed appropriately for the weather. During the winter months, each child should be sent with a set of gloves and a hat for outdoor play. We will be going outside as long as the weather permits.

A change of clothes should be included daily in your child's book bag, complete with underwear, socks, and a weather appropriate outfit.

Please be sure that children are sent to school in clothes that they can manage by themselves before and after toileting. Tights and Belts often cause frustration and can lead to toileting accidents.

LABEL EVERYTHING!!! TreeHouse cannot assume responsibility for personal belongings that are brought to school. Please **label everything** with your child's name. This includes coats, sweaters, jackets and book bags.

SCHOOL BAGS Children may bring a school bag to class. Make sure that your child's name is on the bag. It is preferred that the children's school bags be simple so they can manage it themselves.

Since teachers do not check school bags, please be sure to put notes and book orders in your child's hanging file folder. The teachers will check these folders daily for any correspondence from you. It is a good idea for you to check your child's file and bookbag at the end of each day for anything we may be sending home to you.

TOYS The classrooms are adequately equipped with toys, games, and materials of interest to young children**. We ask that personal toys be left at home**. It is difficult to be responsible for personal play items as they can be easily damaged, misplaced, or lost at school.

Potty Training Guidelines

TreeHouse implements the following guidelines.

Please know- potty training in a childcare setting is drastically different from training at home.

I found a wonderful description for a potty trained child:

A potty trained child is one who can do the following:

1. Be able to TELL the adult they have to go potty BEFORE they have to go. They must be able to say the words “I have to go potty” BEFORE they have to go.
2. Be able to pull down their underwear and pants and get them back up without assistance.
3. Be able to wipe themselves after using the toilet.
4. Be able to get off the potty by themselves.
5. Be able to wash and dry their hands.
6. Be able to go directly back to the room without directions.
7. Be able to postpone going if they must wait for someone who is in the bathroom or if we are outside and away from the toilet.

The first one is the key to successful training. Children who are ready to train have the ability to perceive events that are going to happen BEFORE they happen. Because we cannot allow children to just go in and out of the room to freely use the potty they MUST be able to tell us so that we can accompany them into the room and supervise them (2 year olds). At home, you can allow them free access to the bathroom if you choose. We are prohibited by our regulations to allow them to go unaccompanied (2 year olds). Because of this they need to learn that they must tell the adult they have to go BEFORE they have to go. We are unable to accept signs that the child has to go or nonverbal behavior. We strongly encourage “I have to go potty.”

In a Child Care Center, there are things we CAN do:

1. We start reading potty books and talking about going potty in the big girl or big boy potty during changing.
2. We have the child sit on the potty during natural transition times (before and after meals, before and after naps, and diaper changes.)
3. We practice with them getting their pants up and down on their own and handwashing.
4. We will supervise them and watch for signs that they have to go or are going and get them off to the potty.

5. We keep close communication with the parents about any indicators suggesting the child is ready.

There are also things we **CANNOT** do:

We do not put kids on a potty schedule where they go every half hour or hour. We have learned that this has very little benefit to the child.

Please don't expect the same performance here as at home. Children who have been successful at home are sometimes unsuccessful here for a number of reasons:

1. Kids are not trained at home to tell the parents they have to go BEFORE they have to go but rather are allowed free unsupervised access to the bathroom in the home. Again, the child must be able to tell us BEFORE. They are not allowed to leave the classroom without an adult and go into the bathroom without supervision (2 year olds).
2. There are many more distractions here with a larger group of kids, toys and bustling activities.
3. They need one to one attention throughout the day in order to keep up with the toileting. Here at school we have multi-level aged children who have various needs and supervision requirements. We cannot exclusively focus on one child but must share our attention among all the children in our care.

Please note: We will not put children into underwear until they have been COMPLETELY accident free HERE for two weeks. The reason for this is:

- To maintain infection control standards for the child care and protect the flooring, furniture, and inventory of the Center.
- Often when children have accidents it isn't discovered immediately. Once the child sits down or walks around a bit the entire room quickly becomes filled with urine soaked footsteps and big soaked spots from the child sitting. And our children love to play and sit on the carpet! Once urine gets into the carpet, it is nearly impossible to clean it down to the pad with regular carpet cleaners.
- When children soil their underwear, it is a very big mess to clean up. Often the poop will soak through their clothes and cause the same problems as the urine accident.
- Diapers are required during nap time until the child has slept through a nap for one full month.

We adhere to the following guidelines regarding potty-training.

Typically, a child who turns 3 before July 31st is placed in our Mixed Ages preschool class. Due to the physical constraints of our building, state mandated staffing

requirements, and the distance from the classrooms to the bathrooms**, any child who is placed in our Mixed Ages classroom must meet the potty trained requirements as listed above (1-7). Any child who does not meet the above requirements will be required to remain in the 2-3 year old classroom.**

Once your child turns 4 years of age, it is required that they are fully potty trained in order to remain at TreeHouse. A child who turns 4 years of age cannot remain in the 2-3 year old classroom.

Meal Time Procedures

Procedures for Infant and Toddler Building (ages 6 weeks to 2 years)

TreeHouse does not provide lunch. You must send lunch for your child in a lunch box with a cold pack to keep the items fresh.

You are required to bring lunch and bottles for your child (formula or breast milk) using the following procedures:

Please send the following in a thermal lunch bag (**labeled with your child's name**) with an ice pack:

- **Formula fed**: Enough bottles (**pre-filled with water to the appropriate ounce level**) to get your child through the day.
- **Formula fed**: Formula **pre-scooped** and **measured** for each feeding and placed into a **formula dispenser**.
- **Breast milk fed**: Enough bottles filled with thawed breast milk to get your child through the day. Place all bottles in a bag labeled with your child's name. Please label bottles as well. You may bring one extra bag of frozen breast milk to keep in the freezer in case of emergency.

Regular food: Place any food items your child may eat for breakfast or lunch in a container from which they can eat. Please remember to include cups and silverware. **Label ALL containers**.

To avoid mix-ups, please remember to **label** with a permanent marker all items sent with your baby/toddler.

The sinks in our classrooms are for handwashing only. For this reason **we are unable** to wash dishes, utensils or bottles. All bottles and formula dispensers, as well as any containers that held food items will be returned to you at the end of the day to be washed at home.

We have plenty of snack and breakfast items on hand to feed toddlers. However, as we are not a food prep center, we do not have the ability to cook or warm any foods.

Thank you so much for helping us to follow this procedure.

Our primary goal is to allow the teachers to spend more time with the infants and toddlers, to keep the babies in full view at all times, and to make feeding more about quality time and less about preparation and clean up. If at any time you have any questions regarding this or any other policy, please feel free to call or email the office. We learn from all questions.

Breakfast

Breakfast is served at TreeHouse from 6:35 am until 8:00 am. We provide:

- cold cereal
- breakfast bars

Your child may bring their own breakfast. Staff stops serving breakfast at 8:00 am.

Lunch

(Our Center does not provide lunch-please bring lunch for your child)

Lunch for your child is to be brought from home. Lunch is self-serve. Please provide a healthy lunch for your child. Some suggestions include:

- Main course (sandwich, leftovers from last night). Thermos ok!
- Sides (chips, fruit, vegetables, snacks, yogurt, applesauce etc.) as many as your child can consume.
- Drink (water bottles are great….avoid sugary drinks.)
- Send utensils as needed.

Please send lunch in a **labeled** lunch bag with a cold pack. **We cannot refrigerate lunches. Meal times** provide great opportunities for **children** to practice social, language and **self- help skills**.

Illness Guidelines

Providing a safe and healthy environment requires establishing policies and procedures for handling childhood illness. When a child becomes seriously ill or hurt at school, parents are called so that the child can be picked up.

Illness is defined as having a temperature of 100.6 degrees or above, multiple instances of vomiting/diarrhea or one of the items listed below. Your child should be symptom and fever free WITHOUT fever reducing medicine such as Tylenol and Ibuprofen for at least 24-hours before returning to school. This ensures your child is not contagious and also allows them the time they need to recover from the illness. Please make arrangements with relatives, friends, neighbors, or a sitter to pick up your child when he/she is ill at school. It is always a good idea to have a backup plan for sick childcare for days when children must be kept home from school. We realize that sometimes you are faced with a difficult decision as to whether or not to send your child to school if he/she is not feeling well. To assist you, read over the following guidelines. Please keep them in mind when trying to decide whether or not to keep your child home from school along with consideration of our other children and staff. ***We reserve the right to request a doctor's note prior to returning to school.***

Your child is to stay at home if there is:

- Rash: Unusual rash or spots that have NOT been evaluated by a physician and are spreading. Your child should remain home until the cause is determined. A physician note stating that the child may return to school may be required. If due to chicken pox, the child is to remain home until all lesions are crusted.
- Hand, Foot, and Mouth Disease: Children with suspected or confirmed Hand-Foot-and-Mouth Disease must remain home while fever is present, while drooling from mouth sores cannot be controlled, or while open/blistered lesions are present. Children may return when fever-free for 24 hours without medication, lesions are dry/healing, and the child feels well enough to participate in normal activities.
- Impetigo (infections of the skin): child can not attend until either until lesions are healed or twenty-four (24) hours after medical treatment has started.
- Ringworm: Can attend school once treatment is started and lesions are covered.

- Strep throat: or a sore throat that is accompanied by a fever and enlarged nodules in the neck. A child may return to school twenty-four (24) hours after antibiotic treatment is begun and is fever free.
- Persistent pain: A child complains of severe, persistent pain. This child should be referred to a physician for evaluation.
- Fever: A child's temperature (taken under the arm) is above 100.6 degrees or 1-2 degrees above the child's normal temperature. If your child is sent home because of a fever, vomiting, or diarrhea, he/she must remain home until they have been symptom free without medicine for 24 hours.
- "Cold" and /or persistent cough: If obviously ill – lethargic (very tired), nose running continuously, excessively coughing and child has cold symptoms serious enough to interfere with the child's ability to learn (please carefully evaluate if your child has a history of asthma).
- Conjunctivitis (Pink Eye): If reddening of the white of the eye or inner eyelids is observed which may be accompanied by drainage (pus), itching, or pain, child cannot attend school until medical attention has been received and medication has been administered for twenty- four (24) hours. A physician must evaluate the child and state that the student may return to school.
- Scabies: A contagious skin disease caused by the "itch mite". Children can return to school when adequately treated with the lotion prescribed by the health care provider.
- An injury sustained at home and requires medical treatment.

Should these symptoms develop while at school, the child will be cared for while arrangements are made to have him/her picked up from school. If a symptom persists or if a communicable disease is confirmed (measles, chicken pox, hand foot and mouth), admittance may require a statement from the child's physician declaring the condition non-contagious.

If a child is exposed to or contracts a communicable disease, it is essential that this information be reported to the teacher. Information of possible exposure will be posted for the class(es) involved and/or sent home to class(es). If a child will be absent from school because of illness, the early childhood office and/or child's classroom teacher should be notified.

Medications

If a child needs to take oral medication, including over-the-counter drugs, the following procedure must be followed:

1. The medication shall be in the original container with the child's name and labeled with the physician's prescription.
2. Medication may be dispensed by the Early Childhood staff upon written request of the parents. Parents will need to complete a Medical Authorization form. This must include the parent's signature.
3. The parent/guardian will deliver all medication to be administered at school to the Preschool office. Medications are not to be transported in backpacks.

Head Lice Policy

Head lice are a common childhood condition; however, to protect the health and comfort of all children, the preschool maintains a strict head lice policy.

If live lice or nits are discovered on a child, the child will be excluded from school immediately. The child may return only after appropriate treatment has been completed and the child is completely lice-free and nit-free.

Upon return, if live lice or nits are still present, the child will not be permitted to attend and must receive additional treatment.

Parents are required to notify the preschool promptly if lice are identified at home. The preschool will notify families in the affected classroom while maintaining strict confidentiality.

We strongly encourage families to check their child's hair regularly and after group activities or sleepovers. Consistent cooperation between home and school is essential in preventing the spread of lice within our preschool community.

Brightwheel Program

We use the Brightwheel program here at TreeHouse. Important messages and updates from the Director will come from Brightwheel. The day to day interactions between teachers and families will also occur in Brightwheel. It is a free app (available on both iPhones and Android phones). With it, we are able to give you updates throughout the day on your child's TreeHouse journey. This includes photos and videos, explanations of activities, centers and games, and for the younger kiddos it even shows nap times, diaper changes, and what they've eaten. It's an amazing program and we're proud to offer it for free to all families. In addition, grandparents and other family members can sign up to receive this information as well. **We require that at least one custodial parent be actively signed up and using Brightwheel.**

Signing up is simple. We'll enter your name, email and phone number into our system (tying you to your child's profile), then you'll receive an invitation to join. You simply sign in using the email address you provided us with and create your own password. Then you're connected to your child's profile and can begin communicating with their teacher(s).

If you have any questions about the program or any trouble logging in or communicating with the staff, please reach out to the Director of TreeHouse. You can email the director at nancys@sp4u.org.

Parent/Guardian Signature Page

I/We, _____ the parents of _____, have received, read, had the opportunity to ask questions about, understand and agree to abide by the policies set forth in the TreeHouse at St. Paul's parent handbook. Furthermore, I/We agree to abide by the policies set forth in the manual. I/We understand that the policies described in the Parent Handbook are not conditions of enrollment, and the language does not create a contract between TreeHouse at St. Paul's and the parents. TreeHouse at St. Paul's reserves the right to alter, amend, or otherwise modify these guidelines, in its sole discretion, without prior notice.

I/We also understand that future questions regarding policies in the parent handbook may be directed to the center Director.

_____

Parent/Guardian Signature Date

SIGN AND RETURN THIS PAGE TO THE TREEHOUSE OFFICE.